The Mural [Prose Sample] | Historical Drama | 630 words

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Summary: Set in the 16th century, inside a Benedictine monastery abbey, the sample follows the POV of Brother Pierre as he takes on the duty to guide a young and seemingly enthusiastic novice named Stefan.

Note: Any archaic word usage or ideology found in the sample are not representative of my own personal views.

“Brother, do you see this?” Stefan asked Pierre, his face paler than the grey of the stony walls. Even without looking, Pierre knew what it was. Every young novice discovered the refectory hall mural to similar shock.

Pierre didn't know who had commissioned the artwork, but it was old, older than the abbey. The mural depicted men and women in prostration before demons and skeletons roasting their fellow men over a ravenous red fire. Colored in soot blacks and blood reds, it was meant to be noticed, to elicit fear, and then to be reported. Whilst perhaps not intentional, it had become an initiation rite over the years.

To Pierre, however, it was a poorly envisioned drill. The shock did little more to instil regurgitated dogma than to develop any credible worldview. Watching the boy's reaction only confirmed that.

The Devil is more subtle, boy.

Yet, there was something in it for judging the temperance of young minds. So, he let the boy indulge his emotions. "I see it, Novice Stefan. What are you going to do about this?" Pierre asked as he found a seat amongst some of the other brothers and poured himself some wine.

There was no answer from the novice. He stood affixed in front of the mural with a confused half-grimace. Pierre wondered if sixteen was the right age for taking vows. But then again, he was only twenty when he had set out as an observer monk with the outriders. Naturally, he had witnessed many more visceral sights than this, and had even partaken in some himself.

"H-how… but this…" the boy finally managed to squeak out a few words. But before Brother Pierre could make a joke of it, the young novice had already fetched a ladder and a dirty rag from the corner of the room—where Brother Jurgen had left the custodial equipment—and had begun rubbing the ancient mural off, possibly into the next life.

The boy's ferocity in removing the *resident heretics* was unnerving yet fascinating. "What are you doing?" Pierre asked.

"Getting rid of this profane work!" the boy shouted in less than a kind tone.

"It's a mural, boy. You aren't defeating the devil today," Pierre said as he took another sip from his cup. "But I appreciate your enthusiasm. Now come down." Brother Pierre gestured the boy over.

"Was I not meant to?" Stefan asked, panting as he cautiously took the seat next to Pierre. "I know it seems unorthodox, but I've been told I lack enough conviction. I hope to change that while I am here."

"No. You aren't meant to erase a significant part of the abbey's history. Unless the winds have finally changed and the duke is considering Mohammedanism," Pierre remarked, hoping to get a chuckle out of the boy or anyone at the table.

"So, maybe that is the test!" Stefan exclaimed.

"Please refrain from any acts of apostasy while under my guidance." Pierre took another sip. It was best to steer young minds away from other *heretical* theologies at this stage. The abbot would not tolerate another infraction. Even so, Pierre understood why the novice would make the jump to such a conclusion. The boy had a zeal for duty, if not the right temperament. Pierre could work with that.

"Stefan, you need only convince yourself of your conviction to the Lord," Pierre said, trying to comfort the novice. "And don't worry. Teaching you how to differentiate between how you interpret the Lord's will and how you serve the abbey is my job."

"Thank you, Brother Pierre. I will keep that in mind."

"Good. Come, let us join the other brothers for lunch. Go to the kitchen and ask Brother Lucas for some of that delectable gruel everyone's having."